The Grinches Attack Christmas

A Christmas game of hidden Grinches, secret powers, and midnight mischief

Game Manual

Somewhere between the last carol and the first light of Christmas morning, the Grinches have crept into the village. They look just like everyone else. Each night they strike; each day the village gathers to root them out. Trust no one, protect the ones who matter, and keep Christmas alive until dawn.

The Goal

Grinches Attack Christmas is a social game of hidden roles for a group. Every player is secretly dealt a character. Most belong to one of two teams — the Christmas Team or the Grinch Team — and your team decides how you win. The catch: you only know your own card. Everyone else is a mystery to be figured out through what they do and say.

The game alternates between night, when characters secretly use their powers, and day, when the whole village debates and votes someone out. Play continues, night after night, until one side achieves its goal.

The Teams

Christmas Team	The heroes of the season — Santa, his helpers, and a cast of holiday legends. They don't know who among them is a Grinch. They win by finding and eliminating every Grinch.

Grinch Team	The villains hiding in plain sight. They know each other and scheme together each night. They win the moment they equal or outnumber everyone else at the table, unless the Christmas side still has a real way to fight back (an unused power that can eliminate a Grinch, or a living Cupid pairing). Once that's gone, the Grinches win.
Moderator	Sam the Snowman narrates the game and belongs to no team. If nobody is dealt Sam, the app can run the narration itself.

Setting Up

1. Choose the characters. Pick which cards will be in play for your group. A typical mix is mostly Christmas characters with one to three Grinches hiding among them, plus any special roles you like. More Grinches make for a harder fight.

2. Deal one card to each player. Each player secretly looks at their own card and keeps it hidden. Any leftover cards form the center — face down, out of play, but sometimes reachable by certain powers (like the Wet Bandits).

3. Pick a narrator. Sam the Snowman runs the night. This can be a dedicated player holding the Sam card, or the app itself.

4. Play through the first night, then your first day, and continue until one team wins.

The Night

At night, everyone closes their eyes. The narrator wakes each character in a set order, one at a time, so they can secretly use their power — choosing a target, learning a secret, or striking in the dark. Nobody should ever see who else is awake. When the last role has acted, the night's results are worked out and morning comes.

You don't need to memorise the order — the narrator (or the app) calls each role at the right moment. The full waking order and every power is detailed in the character section below.

The Day

When day breaks, the narrator announces what happened overnight — usually who, if anyone, was lost. Then the whole village talks it out. Anyone may accuse, defend, question, or bluff. This debate is the heart of the game: the Christmas team is hunting for Grinches, and the Grinches are trying to look perfectly innocent.

After the discussion, the village votes to eliminate one player (or, if you prefer, no one). The player voted out reveals nothing unless a rule says otherwise, and the game moves to the next night. A few characters care especially about the vote — Charlie Brown dies on an exact tie, and Bad Santa must have slipped up during the day's talk.

Winning the Game

Christmas wins when every Grinch has been eliminated.

They win the moment they equal or outnumber everyone else at the table, unless the Christmas side still has a real way to fight back (an unused power that can eliminate a Grinch, or a living Cupid pairing). Once that's gone, the Grinches win. (In a total-elimination game, they instead win only once the entire Christmas team is gone.)

The lovers win in one special case: if Cupid linked two players from opposite teams and those two are the last players left alive, their love wins out over either team.

A handful of characters bend these rules — Burgermeister only wins if the Grinches do, and Krampus can grow the Grinch team mid-game. Their entries below spell out the details.

The Characters

Roles that wake at night, in the order they are called

These characters are woken by the narrator during the night to use their powers. They are listed here in the exact order they wake.



Sam the Snowman

Moderator

How it plays: The narrator and referee. Sam is awake the entire game, reads the night aloud, wakes each role in turn, and keeps track of everything that happens. Sam never holds a card in play, casts no vote, and takes no night action of their own.

Winning: Sam has no team and cannot win or lose — they simply make sure the story is told correctly.

Every winter tale needs a voice to tell it. Perched at the edge of the North Pole with a corncob pipe and a banjo, Sam the Snowman has seen every Christmas that ever was. He remembers who was naughty, who was nice, and exactly what happened on the longest nights of the year — and tonight, he'll narrate one more.



Cupid

Christmas Team

How it plays: On the first night, Cupid chooses two players and secretly links them as lovers. From then on, if either lover dies — by any means — the other immediately dies of a broken heart.

Winning: Cupid wins with the Christmas team. But if the two lovers are on opposite teams and end up as the last two players alive, the lovers win together instead — love conquers all.

At night: Night 1 only — “Cupid, wake up. Choose two players to meet under the Mistletoe and fall in love.” Then everyone checks their card to learn if they're in love, and the Christmas Lovers wake to find each other.

While the Grinches sharpen their schemes, a smaller mischief is loose in the snow. Cupid slips between the sleeping villagers and ties two hearts together with a ribbon nobody can see. It is a dangerous gift: bound souls share a single fate, and a love that crosses enemy lines can rewrite how the whole night ends.



Scott Calvin

Christmas Team

How it plays: On the first night, Scott Calvin learns which player was dealt Santa. If the Wet Bandits are in the game (cards may have moved), he checks again on the second night to confirm who Santa is now. The moment Santa dies, Scott Calvin inherits Santa's nightly naughty-or-nice check for the rest of the game.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

At night: Night 1 — “Scott Calvin, wake up. Santa Claus, stick out your thumb so Scott Calvin can see who you are.” If the Wet Bandits are in play, he's woken again on Night 2 to re-check who Santa is now. Once Santa dies, he is asked Santa's question instead (below).

An ordinary father once put on a certain red coat and discovered the job came with it. Scott Calvin knows better than anyone that the role of Santa can pass to a new pair of shoulders overnight. He keeps a careful eye on who's wearing the suit — and if the sleigh ever needs a new driver, he's ready to take the reins.



Wet Bandits

Christmas Team

How it plays: On the first night only, the Wet Bandits may steal one card — either a face-down card from the center or another player's card — and look at it. The stolen card becomes their new role for the rest of the game. If they robbed a player, that player receives the Wet Bandits card (or a center card) and doesn't know their role has changed.

Winning: Wins with whatever team the stolen card belongs to — so their loyalty is only decided the moment they strike.

At night: Night 1 only — “Wet Bandits, wake up. You may steal the center card or another player's card and look at it. If you steal a card, put the Wet Bandit card in the center. If you stole another player's card, they will get the center card.”

Two burglars who could never leave a house the way they found it. The Wet Bandits creep through the village on the first night, pockets open, and swap a card right out from under a sleeping neighbour. Whoever they rob wakes up someone entirely new — and the bandits themselves become whatever they managed to grab.



Elf on the Shelf

Christmas Team

How it plays: Each night, the Elf on the Shelf secretly points to one player (never themselves) and protects them. That player cannot be killed that night. The Elf may not protect the same player two nights in a row.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

At night: Every night — “Elf on the Shelf, wake up. Who would you like to protect tonight?”

It watches. That's the whole job — to sit very still on the shelf and see everything. But this elf does more than report back to the North Pole: each night it chooses one soul to keep safe, spreading its little arms over them so that whatever the darkness sends, it cannot land. It just can't guard the same friend twice running, or the Grinches would learn its pattern.



Grinch

Grinch Team

How it plays: Each night, the Grinches wake together, silently agree on one player, and kill them. With three Grinch cards in the game there can be up to three of them plotting as a team.

Winning: They win the moment they equal or outnumber everyone else at the table, unless the Christmas side still has a real way to fight back (an unused power that can eliminate a Grinch, or a living Cupid pairing). Once that's gone, the Grinches win. (Or, in a total-elimination game, once the Christmas team is entirely gone.)

At night: Every night — “Grinches, wake up. Who would you like to kill tonight?”

Every Who in Whoville was singing, and the Grinch's heart was two sizes too small to bear it. Now he's brought friends. Each night they slink down from the mountain, put their green heads together, and choose a light to snuff out. They don't need to win every heart — just enough of them to make the singing stop.



Krampus

Grinch Team

How it plays: Krampus wakes with the Grinches. Once per game, instead of letting the night's victim die, Krampus may drag them onto the Grinch team — they wake as a Grinch from then on, corrupted rather than killed.

Winning: Wins with the Grinch team.

At night: One use per game — “Krampus, wake up. Would you like to turn this victim into a Grinch?”

Saint Nicholas rewards the good; his shadow handles the rest. Krampus comes clattering with chains and a bundle of birch, and where the Grinches would simply end a life, he offers something worse — he hauls the wicked-hearted down into his own company and makes them one of the horde. Once a season, a victim doesn't die. They turn.



Mrs. Claus

Christmas Team

How it plays: Each night, Mrs. Claus is shown who the Grinches attacked. She has two one-time powers: once per game she may save a player from death with a nice gingerbread cookie, and once per game she may poison a player with a bad one. Each can only be used a single time all game.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

At night: Every night — “Mrs. Claus, wake up. Would you like to save this person with a nice gingerbread cookie?” and “Would you like to poison anyone with a not-so-nice gingerbread cookie?” (each is one use per game).

Behind every Santa is someone who actually runs the North Pole. Mrs. Claus sees the night's cruelty before anyone else does, a tray of cookies cooling at her elbow. One is baked with love and can pull a soul back from the brink. One is baked with something far darker. She has exactly one of each, and a long memory for who deserves which.



Santa Claus

Christmas Team

How it plays: Each night, Santa secretly chooses one player and learns whether they are on the Grinch team or the Christmas team — naughty or nice. He gathers this knowledge quietly and must survive long enough to use it in the day's debate.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

At night: Every night — “Santa Claus, wake up. Which player would you like to know if they are naughty or nice?”

He knows if you've been bad or good. That was always the legend, and here it is the literal truth: each night Santa reads one name off his list and the answer comes back clear as sleigh bells — naughty or nice. His trouble is telling the village what he knows without painting a target on his own red coat.



Belsnickel

Christmas Team

How it plays: Each and every night, Belsnickel chooses one player he believes is attacking Christmas and kills them. He is a weapon for the good side — but he acts on suspicion alone, and he can absolutely be wrong.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

At night: Every night — “Belsnickel, wake up. Who do you believe is attacking Christmas and would like to kill?”

Fur-clad and grumbling, Belsnickel arrives with a switch in one hand and treats in the other, convinced he can tell a rascal on sight. He's Christmas's own enforcer, prowling every night to strike down whoever he's decided is rotten. The danger is his certainty: an innocent villager looks a great deal like a Grinch when Belsnickel's temper is up.



Buddy the Elf

Christmas Team

How it plays: Once per game, Buddy may secretly swap two players. Any fate aimed at one of them that night — a Grinch kill, a poison, anything — follows the swap and lands on the other instead.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

At night: One use per game — “Buddy the Elf, wake up. Would you like to switch two players' seats tonight?”

Raised by elves, powered by sugar and sincerity, Buddy doesn't fully understand the danger he's in — which is exactly what makes him miraculous. One time, at just the right moment, he'll cheerfully switch two people around in a burst of enthusiasm, and a blow meant for one lands harmlessly on someone else. He only gets to be that lucky once.

Non-Waking Roles

Characters who never wake at night — but still shape the game

These characters have no night action to perform, so the narrator never wakes them. Some are ordinary villagers; others carry a rule that triggers on its own — when they die, when the vote ties, or when they break their silence.



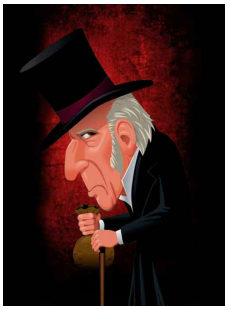
Elf

Christmas Team

How it plays: A regular elf with no special night power. Elves are the backbone of the Christmas team: they listen, they argue, and they vote. Several Elf cards are usually in the game.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team by helping vote the Grinches out.

Not every hero has a magic trick. The workshop runs on ordinary elves — thousands of small hands doing honest work — and Christmas is defended the same way. An Elf has no gadget and no secret sight, only a sharp ear for a lie and a vote that counts exactly as much as anyone's. Together, they are the reason the Grinches can't simply win.



Ebenezer Scrooge

Christmas Team

How it plays: Scrooge is on the Christmas team but is bound by a curse of speech: he may only mumble or say the words "BAH HUMBUG" for the entire game. If he says anything else, he is eliminated on the spot.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team — if he can help without ever breaking his silence.

Before the ghosts got to him, Ebenezer Scrooge had exactly two words for the season, and he means to use them. He's on the side of good now, technically — but the old miser can't manage a civil sentence to save his life. Two words. That's all he's allowed. Everything he wants to warn the village about has to fit inside a grumbled "bah, humbug."



Cindy Lou Who

Christmas Team

How it plays: Cindy Lou Who may secretly peek during the night while the Grinches are awake, hoping to catch them in the act and identify them. But it's risky — if the Grinches notice her peeking, they will almost certainly kill her for it.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

No more than two, and small enough to believe in Santa still, Cindy Lou Who caught a Grinch red-handed once and asked him why. She's braver than she has any right to be. When the Grinches stir in the dark, she cracks one eye to see their faces — knowing that if they catch her looking, morning may never come for her.



Jack Frost

Christmas Team

How it plays: If Jack Frost is killed, he takes one player of his choosing down with him. His revenge is resolved at the start of the following day — so his killer never walks away clean.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

Cold, elegant, and not the forgiving sort. Jack Frost nips at noses for fun, and he does not intend to freeze alone. Strike him down and his final act is a curl of killing frost aimed at whoever he pleases — by the next morning, they've gone as still and white as he has. Killing Jack Frost is easy. Surviving it is the hard part.



Burgermeister Meisterburger

Christmas Team

How it plays: Burgermeister sits with the Christmas team and is counted as nice — but his heart isn't in it. He only wins if the Grinches win and Christmas is stolen. (For the Grinches' victory condition, he is not counted among their opposition.)

Winning: Wins only when the Grinch team wins. A traitor in Christmas clothing.

The man who outlawed toys. Burgermeister Meisterburger despises the noise, the mess, and the joy of the whole affair, and he'd like nothing better than to see it cancelled. He wears the Christmas colours and sits at the good table — but he's quietly rooting for the mountain to win, and he'll only truly celebrate when the last stocking comes down empty.



Charlie Brown

Christmas Team

How it plays: If the day's vote ends in an exact tie, Charlie Brown is the one who dies. When the village can't decide, his luck decides for them.

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team — if he can dodge the town's worst deadlocks.

Good grief. Some people just can't catch a break, and Charlie Brown is their patron saint. He picked out the saddest little tree in the lot and loved it anyway. So of course, when the village splits down the middle and the vote comes up dead even, the universe shrugs and points at him. Poor Charlie Brown — tie goes to the unluckiest.



Yukon Cornelius

Christmas Team

How it plays: Yukon Cornelius survives the very first night attack made against him — a Grinch strike simply bounces off. After that one save is spent, he's as vulnerable as anyone. (Note: this shields him from a night attack only. A daytime vote still eliminates him like anyone else.)

Winning: Wins with the Christmas team.

The greatest prospector in the North, or so he'll tell you, Yukon Cornelius fears nothing — not the cold, not the Bumble, not a mountain full of Grinches. He's tough enough to shrug off the first blow that comes for him in the dark and keep right on going. But even Yukon can't argue with a town that's made up its mind: when the village votes, his luck runs out like anyone's.



Bad Santa

Grinch Team

How it plays: Bad Santa is a Grinch with a tell: he must say the word "Grinch" out loud at least once during each day's discussion. If a whole day passes and he never said it, he is eliminated for breaking his own rule.

Winning: Wins with the Grinch team.

A department-store Santa with a flask in his boot and no love for the season. He runs with the Grinches, but he can't keep his foul mouth shut — the word slips out of him every single day, whether he means it to or not. Clever villagers listen for it. Careless ones let him blend right in.

Merry Christmas, and good luck. Keep the lights on till morning.